by its desire to strengthen the global commons. As it assumes greater responsibilities and builds more partnerships, it is stepping beyond its immediate past. This evolution of Japan, as it happens, has implications far beyond East Asia. It would mean the arrival of a first-class technology power among the ranks of major players.

Given its trade focus, Japan puts a premium on economic goals that far exceed what other major powers do. Since trade has been the primary driver of its rejuvenation, it understandably dominates its strategic calculations. If a country like India is looking to hedge on its security needs, Japan's similar predicament arises more in the economic domain. This is not going to be easy, particularly with pressures on global supply chains and controls on emerging technologies. Japan's challenge would be to bridge these divides to the extent possible.

Its political diplomacy runs largely parallel to these efforts, obviously giving primacy to the US as its alliance partner. To some extent, Japan's predicament is conceptually the same as that of the rest of Asia. It too is engaged in multipolar diplomacy, no longer dependent completely on others, nor oblivious to the growth around it. If there is a new Asian balance to be forged, Japan cannot be left out of that endeavour. And if ASEAN's centrality is questioned, it is difficult to stand by and just watch a grouping that Japan helped so much to create. Where connectivity is to be encouraged or maritime activity secured, these are no longer matters on which it can remain agnostic. Such situations have led Japan and India to discover each other strategically.

Even though it is coming from a very different place, India has mirror-image requirements that also compel it to look more seriously at Japan. That cooperation with Japan holds tremendous economic and even security potential has been well recognized in New Delhi. The difficulty on the economic side was to get beyond the Official Development Assistance to more substantive trade and investment. Japanese companies have long spoken of the cultural gap with India and contrasted it to the reception that they were accorded in South-East Asia and China. The pre-existence of local businesses, disciplines of a rule-based polity and sensitivity towards favouring foreign players have all been responsible for arduous progress in